MR. LIFE MANAGER · FREE GUIDE

The First Apartment Checklist

Everything to do, buy, and find out — in the order you'll need it.

☐ Check it off — print this and use a pen ★ **You'll miss this in the first 24 hours**

PART 1 Before you sign

Before signing

Have the lease, a pen, your budget and the landlord's contact details. Read at your own pace and get unclear terms explained before signing.

READ THE LEASE — ALL OF IT

Yes, really. Find these and write them down:

- ☐ Rent due date, and the late fee after it
- ☐ Length of the lease, and what happens at the end — does it auto-renew?
- ☐ **Notice required to move out** — check the exact lease terms and local requirements; ask about any unclear deadline.
- ☐ What you pay for vs. what's included: water, trash, heat, electric, internet
- ☐ Rules on guests, pets, subletting, painting, and mounting things on walls
- ☐ How to submit a repair request, and who to call after hours
- ☐ Deposit amount, and the conditions for getting it back

ASK BEFORE YOU SIGN

- ☐ Which utilities do I set up, and with which companies?
- ☐ Is renter's insurance required? *(Get it either way — see Part 3.)*
- ☐ What's the parking situation, and is it extra?
- ☐ Which appliances are included, and who repairs them?
- ☐ Has anything in this unit recently been repaired or had a problem?

> **WHY IT MATTERS**
>
> Almost every expensive surprise in a first apartment is written somewhere in the lease. It's not... that people agree to bad terms — it's that they never read them, so they don't know what they

PART 2 Before you move a single box

A week ahead

SET UP UTILITIES

- ☐ Electric
- ☐ Water & sewer *(often landlord)*
- ☐ **Internet** — book the install now; it's often 1–2 weeks out
- ☐ Gas
- ☐ Trash *(often landlord)*
- ☐ **Choose a payment method and reminders** for each bill. Use autopay only if you can keep the account funded and review charges

WHY IT MATTERS

Record each due date and who pays. If you choose autopay, confirm when withdrawals start an... check the first payment; setting it up does not prove a bill was paid.

CHANGE YOUR ADDRESS

- [ ] USPS mail forwarding
- [ ] Employer / payroll
- [ ] Vehicle registration
- [ ] Auto and health insurance
- [ ] Subscriptions that ship things
- [ ] School or student records
- [ ] Bank and credit cards
- [ ] Driver's license
- [ ] Voter registration
- [ ] Phone
- [ ] Doctor, dentist, pharmacy

PART 3 Move-in day, before you unpack

Allow time to inspect

Inspect while surfaces are visible. Have your phone, key and condition form ready. Home size, access and faults change how long this takes. Save written questions and replies; an unresolved check stays open.

DOCUMENT THE CONDITION OF EVERYTHING

- [ ] **Photograph and video every room**, empty, with the date visible if you can
- [ ] Close-ups of every existing flaw: scuffs, stains, chips, holes, scratched floors, dinged counters, torn screens, cracked tiles
- [ ] Check and photograph inside the fridge and oven, under every sink, inside closets, window frames, and bathroom corners
- [ ] Fill out the move-in condition form if you got one. **If you didn't, email your landlord a list of what you found anyway** — and keep that email.
- [ ] Check accessible outlets, light switches, faucets (hot *and* cold), windows, locks and toilet. Do not use damaged electrical equipment. Record anything you cannot safely check
- [ ] Run the shower briefly to check drainage and whether hot water arrives. Record faults and ask about unresolved supply issues

WHY IT MATTERS

Dated photos and a written condition report help document what was present when you arrive... They do not guarantee a deposit outcome. Keep copies and any reply.

FIND THESE FIVE THINGS AND WRITE DOWN WHERE THEY ARE

- [ ] **Water shutoff valve** — for the whole unit, and under each sink and toilet
- [ ] **Breaker panel** — and which switch controls what
- [ ] **Water heater** — and whether it's yours or shared
- [ ] **Smoke and CO detectors** — locate them and test using their instructions and safe access; report missing or non-working alarms promptly
- [ ] **Fire extinguisher** — where the nearest one is

WHY IT MATTERS

You will not learn where the water shutoff is during a leak. You'll learn it after.

GET RENTER'S INSURANCE

- [ ] Compare coverage, exclusions, deductibles and current quotes before choosing a policy. Check any lease requirement before moving in.
- [ ] Do not assume the landlord's policy covers your belongings. What your own policy covers depends on its terms; ask the insurer about the risks you need covered.
- [ ] Photograph your valuables and keep the receipts somewhere that isn't the apartment

PART 4 The first shopping trip

Day one

This is a reference across several shopping trips. Check existing supplies, surface compatibility, storage and your budget before buying. You do not need all of it on day one — the ★ items are what you'll miss first.

CLEANING — CHECK WHAT YOU HAVE, THEN BUY WHAT THE CHOSEN JOBS NEED

- ☐ ★ Paper towels
- ☐ ★ Dish soap
- ☐ All-purpose cleaner
- ☐ Sponges and microfiber cloths
- ☐ Broom and dustpan
- ☐ Mop and bucket
- ☐ Laundry detergent
- ☐ ★ Trash bags *(check the can size)*
- ☐ ★ Plunger
- ☐ Bathroom cleaner
- ☐ Toilet brush
- ☐ Vacuum or a good sweeper
- ☐ Rubber gloves
- ☐ Dryer sheets or wool balls

> **WHERE TO KEEP IT**
>
> Keep a small set of supplies *in each room where you use them*. A second cheap bottle of bathroom... cleaner buys a behavior change — the bathroom gets wiped when the supplies are already in the

KITCHEN

- ☐ ★ Dish soap, sponge, dish towels
- ☐ ★ One good knife
- ☐ Skillet
- ☐ Baking sheet
- ☐ Spatula, wooden spoon, tongs
- ☐ Colander
- ☐ Food storage containers
- ☐ Oven mitt
- ☐ ★ Can opener
- ☐ Cutting board
- ☐ Saucepan with a lid
- ☐ Mixing bowl
- ☐ Measuring cups and spoons
- ☐ Plates, bowls, cups, silverware
- ☐ Foil, plastic wrap, storage bags
- ☐ Dish rack

BATHROOM

- ☐ ★ Toilet paper
- ☐ ★ Shower curtain, liner, rings
- ☐ Bath mat
- ☐ Basic first aid kit
- ☐ ★ Hand soap
- ☐ Bath towels, hand towels, washcloths
- ☐ Trash can
- ☐ Any medication you take

BEDROOM

- ☐ ★ Sheets — two sets, so laundry day isn't a crisis
- ☐ Comforter or duvet
- ☐ Hangers
- ☐ Curtains or blinds, if the windows are bare
- ☐ ★ Pillows
- ☐ Mattress protector
- ☐ Laundry hamper
- ☐ Alarm clock

THE STUFF NOBODY PUTS ON THE LIST

- ☐ ★ Light bulbs *(check what fits first)*
- ☐ **Toolkit:** hammer, screwdriver with bits, tape measure, pliers, level, utility knife, adjustable wrench
- ☐ Extension cords, power strips
- ☐ Duct tape
- ☐ Step stool
- ☐ ★ Batteries
- ☐ Command strips and picture hardware
- ☐ Flashlight
- ☐ Scissors
- ☐ Fire extinguisher *(kitchen-rated)*

- [ ] Air filters — **check the size on the existing one**
- [ ] Drain hair catcher *(check that it fits your drain)*

PART 5 The first week

Days 1–7

- [ ] **Make your bed properly on night one.** Everything else can wait; sleeping well is what makes the rest of the week possible.
- [ ] Set up the kitchen before anything else — a working kitchen makes the place feel livable, and it's what stops the delivery spending
- [ ] **Give every item an exact home as you unpack it.** Put daily tools at eye level where your hand goes naturally. Use the same location and check that you can find and return it.
- [ ] Put daily-use items within comfortable reach, heavy items low, and less-used items in safe accessible storage
- [ ] Note the trash and recycling schedule, and where the bins go
- [ ] Find the nearest grocery store, pharmacy, urgent care, and laundromat
- [ ] Learn where mail is delivered and how packages are handled
- [ ] Meet at least one neighbor — worth more than it sounds when you're locked out
- [ ] Buy one week of groceries for **three or four meals you already know how to make**
- [ ] Test the smoke detectors; note the air filter size and set a reminder

> **WHY IT MATTERS**
>
> Ambitious grocery shopping in week one becomes food waste in week two. Cook what you... already know until the kitchen works.

PART 6 The first month

Weeks 2–4

SET UP THE SYSTEMS

- [ ] **Review how each bill will be paid** — rent if you can, utilities, phone, insurance
- [ ] Put these on a calendar for the whole year, with reminders: rent (monthly) · air filter checks and replacement per the equipment instructions · alarm testing and battery replacement per the alarm instructions · insurance renewal · **lease end date, and the notice deadline before it**
- [ ] Pick a **home for incoming mail** — process it standing up, near a recycling bin
- [ ] Pick a **home for important documents**: lease, insurance, pay stubs, anything with an account number
- [ ] Pick a **home for keys** by the door, and use it every time

> **WHY IT MATTERS**
>
> A stack of mail is a stack of unmade decisions with deadlines attached. The stack isn't the... problem — the deferred decisions are.

SET THE RHYTHM

- [ ] **A kitchen reset before bed** — dishes in, counters wiped, things put back
- [ ] **Schedule the applicable weekly jobs**, allowing for your home and machine cycles: laundry, bathroom, floors, fridge clear-out. Same day each week, so you stop deciding.
- [ ] Laundry on a schedule, not when you run out of clothes

> **WHY IT MATTERS**
>
> A regular kitchen reset makes the next meal easier. Time it in your own home before choosing a... nightly calendar block.

IF YOU HAVE ROOMMATES

- [ ] **Agree out loud who does what**, and write it down. Not "we'll both do the kitchen" — "you own dishes, I own trash and floors."
- [ ] Decide how shared bills are split, and *who actually pays the company*
- [ ] Agree on guests, quiet hours, and shared groceries **before** it's a problem

- [ ] Name the invisible work too: noticing supplies are low, taking out recycling, scheduling repairs. It's real work, and it's what people end up resenting.

COSTLY The five things that cost people the most

1. **Not documenting move-in condition.** Leaves you with less evidence of the move-in condition.
2. **Missing the move-out notice deadline.** Can have costs under your lease and local rules.
3. **No renter's insurance.** Leaves you relying on whatever coverage and resources you already have.
4. **Aspirational grocery shopping.** Produce rots; delivery fills the gap.
5. **Ignoring small repairs.** Report them in writing, early. A slow drip becomes a ceiling.

Five priorities to track

Everything else on this list gets easier once these are true.

1. Photograph everything before you unpack.
2. Record how and when each bill will be paid.
3. Find the water shutoff and the breaker panel.
4. Give things a home while you're unpacking.
5. Schedule time to reset the kitchen before bed.

This is a multi-stage reference, not one sitting's checklist. Mark completed actions, questions awaiting answers, and jobs still to schedule separately.

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